



In this engraving by Giovanni Stradano, Emperor Commodus shoots an arrow to subdue a leopard. Fighting in the arena as a gladiator was his great passion.

IN CHINA, INCREASING DISSENT caused by the corruption of the eunuchs at the court of Han Emperor Lindi (r. 168–89) and a succession of natural disasters led to the outbreak in 184 of a major insurrection, named the **Yellow Turban revolt** for the color of its supporters' headgear. Up to 400,000 rebels swept westward towards the capital. Another uprising fueled by the **Five Pecks of Rice** sect then succeeded in taking over Sichuan in the southwest. Although the Yellow Turbans had been largely crushed by early 185, the **control of the Han emperor was ever weakening**. After Lingdi died in 189, he was replaced by his younger half-brother **Xiandi** (r. 189–220) but he never exercised real power. Instead, control of the empire fell to Han general **Cao Cao**, who contended for 30 years with a **series of rival warlords**, notably **Liu Bei** in the southwest and **Sun Quan** in the south.

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THE AGE AT WHICH COMMODUS BECAME SOLE EMPEROR

Commodus (r. 180–92), Marcus Aurelius's son, was the first Roman emperor to succeed his father for 90 years, but he proved to be a **disastrous choice**. In 182, after an assassination attempt on him, apparently organized by his sister Lucilla, Commodus became **increasingly despotic**. Many senators who were implicated in the plot were executed and control of the government fell into the hands of **Tigidius Perennis**, the **praetorian prefect** (the commander of the imperial bodyguard). There were minor wars in Britain and in Dacia (much of modern Romania), but in 185 Perennis was suspected of a plot to make his own son emperor and was executed by his troops. Commodus increasingly **devoted himself to fighting** in the arena as a **gladiator**, while the imperial chamberlain **Cleander** dominated government and sold public offices to the highest bidder. The man in charge of the grain supply, **Papirius Dionysius**, engineered a shortage that led to Cleander's downfall. This did not result in a more stable government, as his replacement only lasted a short time before being murdered. Commodus increasingly identified himself with **Hercules** (the Greek hero) and renamed Rome after himself—*colonia Commodiana*. At the end of 192, the praetorian prefect **Laetus** was convinced that Commodus was planning to have him killed and on **New Year's Day 193** took the initiative and had the emperor **poisoned** and, when that did not work, **strangled**.



The Severan arch in Leptis Magna (in modern Libya) commemorates a visit by the North African emperor to his home town.

“BE HARMONIOUS WITH EACH OTHER, ENRICH THE SOLDIERS, IGNORE ALL OTHERS...”

Septimius Severus, dying words as quoted in Book 77 of Roman historian Dio Cassius's *Roman History*, 211

IN 193, AFTER THE MURDER OF COMMODUS, Helvius Pertinax (126–93), the prefect of the city, was declared emperor, but he was murdered after three months. This was followed by rival claimants to the throne engaging in an auction outside the praetorian camp to decide who would be emperor. **Didius Julianus** (133–93) won, but



Buying loyalty
The larger bribes offered to the troops by Didius Julianus meant that he won the auction to be emperor.

his reign was short, as almost immediately the frontier armies rebelled: the army on the Danube proclaimed **Septimius Severus** (c. 145–211) emperor, while the Syrian legions raised their commander **Pescennius Niger** (c. 135–94) to the imperial throne. Severus reached Rome first and, after granting the title of Caesar (junior emperor) to **Clodius Albinus**, governor of Britain, he turned east where, in spring 194, his armies defeated Niger at the **Battle of Issus** in Syria. Severus stayed in the east and in 195 attacked the Parthian Empire. But he was forced to return west to deal with Albinus, who had revolted, and who was killed near Lugdunum (modern Lyon, France) in 197. Severus then returned to Parthia, this time occupying the capital Ctesiphon in 197. He pushed the line of Roman control toward the Tigris and created the **new province of Mesopotamia**.

Trouble in Britain brought the aging emperor to the province in 208. A large-scale Roman advance forced the Caledonians and Maetae north of the provincial frontier to come to terms in 209,



JULIA DOMNA (170–217)

The daughter of a Syrian high priest, Julia Domna married Septimius Severus in 187. A prophecy had predicted that she would wed an emperor, and so it turned out. Forceful and intelligent, she failed to mediate between her sons Caracalla and Geta after their father's death and to prevent Geta's murder. When Caracalla was killed, she deliberately starved herself to death in protest, a move that rallied support for the remaining Severan family.

but they soon broke the peace and a new campaign was launched in 210. Severus was by now very ill, and his son Caracalla took over. In February 211 **Severus died** in Eboracum (modern York, England) and handed succession jointly to sons Caracalla and Geta. After the Scottish war, both rushed back to Rome, but their **joint rule was short-lived**: Caracalla had Geta murdered in December 211.

